Twilight zone

The deeper you go in the ocean, the less light there is. About 660 ft (200 m) below the surface there is only faint blue light left. It is like the light we see at nightfall, so this region of the ocean is called the twilight zone. The light is too dim to support the drifting algae that feed a lot of marine life in the oceans. So the animals of the twilight zone must either swim up to the sunlit zone to find food, eat scraps, or prey on each other.

UP FROM THE DEEP

Many animals including copepods and these small lantern fish live in the twilight zone during the day, but swim up toward the surface at night to feed on algae and other plankton. At dawn, they sink back into the twilight zone, hoping to avoid being eaten by herring and other schooling fish. Compared to the fish's size, these are epic journeys, taking up to three hours each way. Since this animal movement happens in most of the world's oceans, every day of the year, this has been called the greatest migration on Earth.

CHEMICAL LIGHT

The bodies of many twilight-zone animals are dotted with light-producing photophores. They include squid, fish, and jellyfish such as this one, known to scientists as atolla. The light they produce is called bioluminescence. It is created by a chemical reaction that releases energy as light. Some animals use the light to attract prey, but others use it to confuse their enemies.

FATAL ATTRACTION

The small animals that live in the twilight zone by day are hunted by other animals such as this firefly squid. Covered in hundreds of special light-producing organs, it is likely that the firefly squid uses these to attract its prey within range of its long, sucker-covered feeding tentacles.